

Your Meeting Has Been Summarized

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Nobody in the meeting was fully present for it, because everyone had already delegated their attention to the summary that would arrive afterward, the way a person at a concert films the stage instead of watching it, trusting the footage to have been the experience so the eyes are free to wander. The summary lands within minutes: three bullet points, an action-item list, a sentiment rated implicitly positive. It reads clean and confident, the way a memory never does, and this is the first sign of what has actually happened. The document is not compressing the meeting. It is replacing it.

Ask someone a week later what was decided and they will open the summary rather than search their own memory, not because the memory has faded unusually fast but because it was never fully formed to begin with, half-attention spent on a call that half-attention already knew would be reconstituted for it later. The record has become more durable than the event, and durability, once it's cheap enough, starts to outcompete presence for the thing everyone actually treats as real. Ask what was said, in the room, in the specific words that were used, and there is no answer, because nobody was listening for the words. They were listening for whether the meeting would produce a summary they'd be comfortable being associated with, which is a different activity from listening.

The strange part isn't that the technology can compress a conversation. It's that the compression arrived and the conversation quietly adjusted its own importance downward to match, agreeing without a vote that the thing worth remembering was never the hour spent, only the three lines it could be reduced to. Everyone attended on behalf of the minutes. The minutes were the only one of the two that showed up in full.